7

THE QUESTION OF AMERICAN STRATEGY IN THE INDO-PACIFIC

From the beginning of the Republic, Americans have been drawn to the Pacific. Fur traders and wagon train pioneers were preceded in their western expansion across the continent by American ships heading into the great western sea. As American engagement with the vast Pacific world, whether public or private, waxed and waned for decades, individual initiative often seemed unconnected to a broader national strategy beyond desiring the region remain free and open to all states.[1]

Indeed, a self-conscious, coherent, and well-resourced American global strategy is a relatively new phenomenon, coming fullest into being during the early Cold War with the assumption of worldwide commitments. Even then, the Pacific Ocean region was just one part of a necessarily broad global picture. Perhaps only with China's rise after the Cold War, and with Asia becoming a vital part of the global economy, can one realistically talk about the concomitant emergence of a US global strategy at the center of which lies the Indo-Pacific. Yet,

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